



FITNESSWISE

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Busting myths in the world of sport science

Here are the ten **most misunderstood fitness topics** the author has discussed with coaches around the world.

Over the past 30-plus years of coaching, I've been blessed to meet many coaches from around the globe, each with a rich tapestry of backgrounds, experiences, and achievements. Reflecting on this journey, I shall share the 10 most misunderstood topics and headlines that I've discussed over the years with many legendary coaches in the world of sports science.

Talent is paramount

We have all heard this statement many times — from skill coaches to parents and many itinerants — however, it's not as simple as that. Yes, talent helps, but all things being equal, mental resilience can be the key factor in securing victory on the big stage. Similarly, 'robot' athletes who fail to communicate will ultimately never reach their full potential. My coaching experience has taught me that an athlete with average talent, but a strong mind and perseverance, can indeed outperform a disconnected super-talent on the day.

All athletes are equal

This is a completely false narrative. Even in professional teams today, what suits a successful player is often followed by others, regardless of their own shortcomings.

This approach has repeatedly led to disaster, as many are now witnessing. It is crucial to understand that not all athletes can tolerate the same load. Instead, coaches must assess an athlete's capacities before testing their thresholds.

Working with intelligent categorisation and bandwidths is highly effective. It's no secret that much of our individual programming is done randomly under the guise of 'out-of-the-box' thinking — this is sheer incompetence in an attempt to be different. It's a no-brainer for S&C coaches to adopt and adapt accordingly.

Know-it-all attitude: Self-proclaimed experts or game-changers?

This is perhaps the most dangerous attitude in vogue today, fuelled by social media and personal branding. Nobody will ever know it

all. Without any window dressing, India remains far behind the curve in sports science and allied fields. The more you learn, the more you realise how little you actually know. A willingness to express your point of view and be challenged is essential.

Obscure, myopic thinking is not the sign of a successful S&C coach. Self-branding makes it even more difficult to keep an open mind — 'my way or the highway' is not the right approach.

Programming is constantly evolving and morphing with each specialised athlete. Evaluation and peer reviews are constant and never-ending. Listening is a process that enlightens and challenges me to keep learning.

Textbook learning prepares you for the real world

An ideal life should have a combination of practice and theory. Theoretical knowledge is non-negotiable for a robust foundation, but ultimately, there is no substitute for hands-on experience in developing expertise in coaching.

If you want to stand out as a